

Mosaic

Mosaic is the art of creating images from small pieces of stone, coloured glass or other materials stuck to wet plaster. The pieces are usually small, flat and roughly square and called *tesserae*, but sometime floor mosaics are made of small rounded pieces of stone, called pebble mosaics. The earliest known mosaics are from the second half of the third millennium BCE, in a temple building in Abra, Mesopotamia.

Accomplished Greek mosaicists created detailed pictures with geometric borders, often illustrating mythological subjects or hunting scenes. The Romans enthusiastically adopted them, initially using Greek artists. Their two favoured techniques were *opus vermiculatum*, which used tiny tesserae allowing for fine details and tonal contrasts, and the more common *opus tessellatum*, which used larger tesserae. By the first century CE, Roman mosaics reached a peak. At first, black and white patterns were the most common, but by the second century CE, colourful expressive images became more popular.



'Alexander Mosaic' from Pompeii, c.100 BCE